GAME DESIGN & NARRATIVE ARCHITECTURE

VARUNPASH

A Tale of Ink & Brine

"A cursed galleon sinks every 10 minutes. You die, remember, and come back later each time, with less time and more knowledge. Break the loop before the tide runs out."

THEME	PLATFORM	ART STYLE
THE LOOP (Causal Time Loop)	Web Browser / itch.io (HTML5)	Black-and-White Hand-Inked Manga

1. GAME DESCRIPTION

1.1 Overview & Concept

VarunPash is a narrative time-loop puzzle thriller set aboard the cursed ancient merchant galleon *Jal-Doot*. Trapped in a supernatural maritime pocket of the Indian Ocean, the ship is doomed to sink into the abyss every 10 minutes (600 seconds). The catalyst is the **Kaal Mani**—an ancient crystalline relic locked in the lower cargo hold that distorts the flow of time and summons the colossal mythical sea creature **Makara**.

Unlike conventional time-loop titles where resets grant full restarts, in *VarunPash*, **every death moves the respawn point 30 seconds forward into the timeline**. Loop 1 begins at 0 seconds (calm waters); Loop 2 begins at 30 seconds; by Loop 12 (360s), the player spawns mid-mutiny with knives already drawn. At the 20th death (600s), the player respawns as the hull breaches and water swallows the deck. Knowledge—not physical items—is the sole currency that endures between lives.

1.2 Objectives & Core Gameplay Loop

- **Explore & Investigate:** Navigate top-down 2D pixel-art decks and the dark cargo hold, discovering hidden vent shafts, stern hatches, locked armories, and secret safe combinations.
- **Die to Learn, Remember to Survive:** Experience death as an investigative tool. Being executed by the paranoid Captain reveals his safe code (`7-3-1`); drowning near the port rail reveals the Makara's fatal harpoon wound; touching the relic whispers the sealing chant.
- **Journal Progression:** All discovered clues, door codes, mutiny cues, and tide schedules automatically document into a weathered first-person ship's log (accessed via `J`).
- **Break the Causal Circle:** Piece together the tragedy to evacuate the crew and break the time curse before the 20-tally death counter runs out.

2. GAME CONTROLS & INTERACTION

INPUT / KEY	ACTION	CONTEXT / INTERACTION
`W` `A` `S` `D` / `↑` `←` `↓` `→`	Player Movement	Top-down 8-directional exploration across main deck, quarters, and hold.
`E` or `SPACE` or `Left Click`	Interact / Advance / Advance Manga	• Talk to NPCs and inspect objects (highlighted with lantern glow). • Advance dialogue lines & manga cutscene panels. • Hold for 10s on davit winch plates to lower lifeboats.
`J`	Open / Close Journal	Opens the weathered ship's logbook (Clues, Tide Table, People, Codes). Pauses active ship clock.

INPUT / KEY	ACTION	CONTEXT / INTERACTION
`ESC`	Cancel / Step Away / Skip	Closes active modals (Keypad, Role Card, Journal) or skips cutscenes.
`0` – `9` + `Backspace`	Keypad Entry	Enters 3-digit combination into Captain Nakhuda's strongbox.

> **Interaction Nuances:** Proximity interactions trigger within a 1.2-tile radius. A brief 0.5s grace period is enforced upon loop respawns to prevent accidental immediate inputs. The timeline automatically pauses whenever the Journal, dialogues, or keypads are open.

3. COMPLETE STORY & NARRATIVE ARCHITECTURE

3.1 The Story Spine: The Closed Causal Circle

The merchant galleon *Jal-Doot* departed port with a cargo hold laden with contraband gold and an enigmatic relic: the **Kaal Mani**. Deep in uncharted waters, the sea stopped moving, compasses spun erratically, and the ocean began running backwards.

Three intertwined crises unfold on a single, synchronized timeline:

1. **The Relic (0s – 600s):** The Kaal Mani hums in the lower hold, distorting time and tethering the vessel to the ocean floor.
2. **The Mutiny (360s):** First Mate Kedar Voss leads an armed mutiny against the paranoid Captain Nakhuda Thorne to seize the hold's gold.
3. **The Beast (480s):** The colossal mythical Makara breaches port side, smashing through bulwarks and devastating the galleon.
4. **The Sinking (600s):** The hull buckles under abyssal pressure and sinks to the seabed.

3.2 The Core Twist

> **The Great Reveal:** The petrified grey stone statue standing in the hold clutching a brass locket is *not an ancient relic*—it is **the player from a future loop**. The glowing harpoon already lodged in the Makara's neck and the chant whispered by the relic (in the player's own voice) were left behind by earlier cycles. Chanting directly inside the hold successfully seals the relic and saves the crew, but turns the chanter into stone—and that act of petrification is precisely what initialized the eternal loop. Only by discovering the inscription on the statue's base and chanting from the **upper deck listening grate** can the circle finally be broken.

3.3 Relevance to "The Loop" Theme

- **Temporal Shrinkage:** Unlike standard rogue-lites where time resets to zero, death in *VarunPash* carries a tangible temporal penalty (+30s start delay). Careless deaths leave the player with insufficient time to resolve complex puzzles.
- **Causal Determinism:** The player is both creator and prisoner of the anomaly. The artifacts that aid the player are remnants left behind by their own future choices.
- **Information as the Sole Currency:** Physical items vanish on death, but learned safe combinations, mutiny timings, and beast weaknesses persist permanently in the player's mind and journal.

4. PLAYABLE CHARACTER ROLES & WALKTHROUGHS

Every new game assigns one of three roles, each providing completely distinct routes, social statuses, and puzzle solutions:

ROLE	STARTING LOADOUT	STRENGTHS & ROUTE ACCESS	WEAKNESSES & LIMITATIONS
Navigator	Maritime Sea Chart (Map)	Unlocks hidden stern hatch on deck; trusted by Captain Nakhuda; direct access to the ship's wheel.	Physically fragile; cannot defeat Bosun Hari or First Mate Kedar in combat.
Quartermaster	Armory Key, Hold Key, 6 Gold Coins	Can bribe NPCs with coins; direct physical access to hold and weapons; can overcome Hari and Kedar.	Distrusted by crew; NPCs demand heavy bribes (1 coin per dialogue/favor).
Deckhand	Nothing (Empty Pockets)	Small stature allows navigating the ventilation duct network to bypass locked doors and eavesdrop.	Completely ignored by officers; cannot enter captain's cabin without proof of mutiny.

4.1 Active Playable Walkthrough: The Hero's Sacrifice (All Characters)

The Hero's Sacrifice is the primary canonical ending currently programmed, fully playable, and achievable in the game today. Because this is a time-loop game, completing it relies on a multi-loop strategy: discovering the relic's chant in life, then executing the lifeboat evacuation and self-sacrifice.

> **The Universal Prerequisite — The Suicide Knowledge Run:**
> In your first loop (or any early cycle), descend to the lower hold and interact with the humming Kaal Mani relic. Hold `E` for 1.0 second. You will be vaporized by abyssal energy, but you permanently learn **K_CHANT** (*"...seven syllables... seven tides..."*). This memory flag endures across all subsequent loops and respawns.

A. Navigator Walkthrough — The Hero's Sacrifice:

1. **Spawn & Observe:** Spawn at the stern on the main deck with the Maritime Sea Chart.
2. **Evacuate the Crew (0s – 350s):** Run directly to the starboard davit winch plates. Press and hold `E` for 10 continuous seconds without releasing before ship time reaches 360s.
3. **Crew Boarding:** The progress ring fills (*"LOWERING BOATS..."*). Because this is completed before 360s, Captain Nakhuda emerges safely from his cabin and boards the lifeboats alongside Cook Bhima, Gunner Isha, and Bosun Hari. The lifeboats lower into the sea and sail away safely.
4. **Descend to the Hold:** Walk to the central deck hatch and take the ladder down into the cargo hold.
5. **Perform the Sealing Chant:** Approach the humming Kaal Mani. Because `K_CHANT` is in your memory, the prompt reads *"Hold [E] for 2 seconds to speak the chant"*. Hold `E` for 2 continuous seconds before 590s.
6. **Ending Resolution:** The chant seals the relic, calming the abyssal waters. Grey stone creeps over your arms, petrifying you into the stone statue. The *Hero's Sacrifice* ending cutscene plays, saving the crew while trapping your body in stone.

B. Quartermaster Walkthrough — The Hero's Sacrifice:

1. **Spawn with Keys:** Spawn on deck with the Hold Key, Armory Key, and 6 coins in inventory.

2. **Bribe Hari (Optional Interaction):** Approach Bosun Hari at the starboard lifeboats; you spend 1 coin for his dialogue and secure unrestricted access to the davits.
3. **Lower the Lifeboats:** Stand on the starboard davit winch plate. Hold `E` for 10 continuous seconds before 360s. Captain Nakhuda, Bhima, Isha, and Hari board and row away safely.
4. **Immediate Hold Access:** Use your Hold Key to unlock the main deck cargo hatch directly without needing bypass routes.
5. **The Sacrifice:** Approach the Kaal Mani in the lower hold and hold `E` for 2 seconds to speak the chant before 590s, sealing the beast and turning to stone.

C. Deckhand Walkthrough — The Hero's Sacrifice:

1. **Spawn Empty-Handed:** Spawn with empty pockets, but full access to the ship's iron ventilation grates.
2. **Deck Evacuation:** Head directly to the main deck starboard rail. Hold `E` for 10 continuous seconds at the davit winch before 360s. The crew evacuates safely into the morning mist.
3. **Drop into the Hold:** Slip through the open deck hatch or drop down through the hold ventilation grate.
4. **The Sacrifice:** Approach the humming Kaal Mani, hold `E` for 2 seconds, and speak the 7 syllables to seal the loop.

4.2 Future Planned Milestone: The Golden Path (Design Specification)

Note: The Golden Path represents the complex multi-system puzzle sequence designed in PRD.md and RULES.md §9, planned for full programming in upcoming development milestones:

A. Navigator Route (The Scholar's Path — Planned):

1. Spawn on deck. Consult the Sea Chart to locate the hidden stern hatch leading directly to the upper gallery.
2. Knock on Nakhuda's cabin door (240s–270s). Because you are the Navigator, Nakhuda trusts you and will listen without shooting.
3. Inform Nakhuda of Kedar's impending mutiny. Nakhuda arms himself, neutralizing the 360s assassination.
4. Take the stern stairs to the wheel. Stand on the Helm Plate during 480s–510s to turn the ship and expose the Makara's harpoon wound to Isha's port cannons.
5. Bribe Bosun Hari with hold gold or the deck locket to allow the crew to board the lifeboats.
6. Ascend to the upper deck listening grate and speak the 7-syllable chant before 570s to achieve the *Golden Path*.

B. Quartermaster Route (The Enforcer's Path — Planned):

1. Use your Hold Key to access the lower cargo deck immediately at the start of the loop.
2. Collect the contraband gold bars from the cargo crates.
3. Pay Bosun Hari 3 coins (or 1 gold bar) to secure unconditional control of the starboard davit lifeboats.
4. Approach Kedar Voss before 360s. Offer him a share of the hold gold to buy off his mutiny.

5. With both Nakhuda and the crew secure, coordinate with Gunner Isha at the cannons during the beast breach.
6. Either sacrifice yourself in the hold (*Hero's Sacrifice*) or chant through the grate (*Golden Path*).

C. Deckhand Route (The Shadow's Path — Planned):

1. Enter the ventilation grates located along the port deck rail. Crawl beneath the captain's quarters and galley.
2. Eavesdrop at the galley grate at 300s to record Kedar conspirator dialogue, earning `K_MUTINEER` without dying.
3. Slip through the vent into the Quartermaster's safe room. Input code `7-3-1` into the strongbox to obtain the Helm Key and Armory Key.
4. Rattle the vent near Bosun Hari to lure him away from the lifeboat winch plates.
5. Slip into Nakhuda's cabin with stolen proof of the mutiny to rally the captain before 360s.
6. Execute the final sequence from the listening grate to shatter the curse.

5. DETAILED ENDINGS & TRIGGER CONDITIONS

Ending 1: Coward's End BAD ENDING

Narrative: Overwhelmed by paranoia, the player abandons the ship and crew, lowering a lone lifeboat into the glassy black sea before the beast arrives. The galleon sinks behind you in total silence. You survive, but the loop breaks—leaving you adrift and forever alone in an uncharted sea.

Trigger Conditions: Board a lifeboat alone before 480 seconds while crew members remain aboard. Requires neutralizing Bosun Hari (bribing with 3 coins/gold, defeating him as Quartermaster, or venting past him as Deckhand).

Ending 2: Mutineer's Reign NEUTRAL / DARK

Narrative: Believing Kedar offers the only pragmatic escape, you betray Captain Nakhuda. Kedar shoots the captain during the 360s mutiny and takes command. When the Makara attacks at 480s, Kedar coordinates a devastating double-broadside that repels the monster. With the ship saved, Kedar reveals his true colors: he smiles with his gold tooth and has you locked in the brig forever to protect his secret.

Trigger Conditions: Obtain `K_MUTINEER`, talk to Kedar before 360s and agree to his alliance, let Nakhuda die in the mutiny, and ensure port cannons repel the Makara.

Ending 3: The Hero's Sacrifice BITTERSWEET CANONICAL

Narrative: You hold the davit winch plates for 10 seconds, successfully lowering Captain Nakhuda, Bhima, Isha, and Hari into the lifeboats. As the ship slips beneath the waves, you descend into the flooded hold and chant the 7 ancient syllables directly before the Kaal Mani. The beast recedes and the crew escapes safely to dawn light, but grey stone creeps up your flesh. You petrify into the statue, maintaining the very circle that gave you life.

Trigger Conditions: Complete lifeboat launch with crew aboard, acquire `K_CHANT`, and speak the chant at the relic in the lower hold before 590s.

Ending 4: The Golden Path TRUE / PERFECT ENDING

Narrative: Every loop's lesson converges. You bribe Kedar with hold gold to prevent the mutiny, save Nakhuda, expose the Makara's throat with the helm turn, evacuate the crew, and chant the sacred verses from the *upper deck listening grate* above the hold. The Kaal Mani shatters. The stone statue in the hold crumbles into harmless sand. The *Jal-Doot* sails into morning sunlight, finally free of the time loop.

Trigger Conditions: Bribe Kedar before 360s, keep Nakhuda alive, hold Helm Plate for 15s during 480–510s while Isha fires, discover `K_STATUE_TRUTH`, and read chant from the upper deck grate by 570s.

Ending 5: The Drowned Loop HIDDEN COSMIC ENDING

Narrative: You have died 20 times. All tally marks on the rail are scratched out in blood-rust ink. The final loop begins at exactly 600s: you spawn as the ship plunges straight down into the abyssal trench. You are petrified into stone without having made a choice. The timeline fractures and resets to Loop 1.

Trigger Conditions: Reach the 20th death. Fires automatically upon respawn.

6. ASSET CREDITS & ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

ASSET / LIBRARY	CREATOR / PROVIDER	LICENSE	USAGE IN VARUNPASH
IM Fell English SC	Igino Marini (Google Fonts)	SIL Open Font License	Narration boxes, title cards, captions.
Comic Neue	Craig Hang (Google Fonts)	SIL Open Font License	Manga speech, shout, and whisper bubbles.
Bangers	Vernon Adams (Google Fonts)	SIL Open Font License	Stylized manga sound effect (SFX) typography.
Special Elite	Astigmatic (Google Fonts)	Apache License 2.0	Dialogue boxes, NPC text, button typography.
Pixelify Sans	Stefie Justprince	SIL Open Font License	HUD loop counter, clock timer, system font.
Caveat	Impallari Type	SIL Open Font License	In-game handwritten ship's logbook entries.
Audio Synthesizer	Custom Web Audio API	MIT / Project Original	Procedural gunshots, door knocks, waves, page turns.
Manga Artwork	Antigravity AI Generation	Proprietary Project Art	11 hand-inked manga panels for the intro cutscene.
Engine & Framework	React 18, Vite, Zustand	MIT License	Application lifecycle, state stores, rendering pipeline.

7. MANGA OPENING VISUAL SHOWCASE

The cutscene system utilizes pure black-and-white hand-inked Japanese manga artwork with screentone halftones and zero embedded text, allowing crisp, dynamic typography overlays:



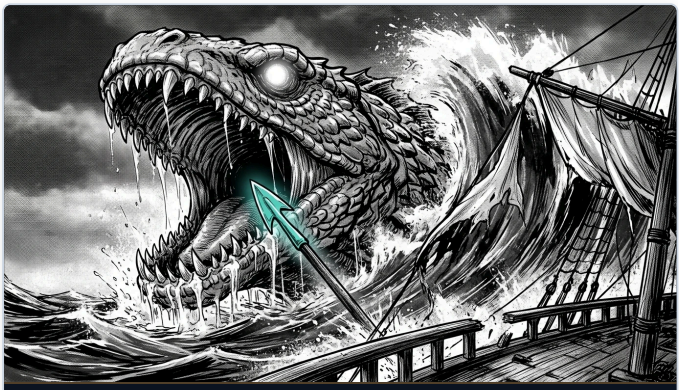
Page 1 • Panel A: The *Jal-Doot* sailing into the moonless sea.



Page 1 • Panel C: Nakhuda & Bhima observing the spinning compass.



Page 1 • Panel D2: First Mate Kedar smiling with his gold tooth.



Page 2 • Panel H: The colossal Makara breaching port side.



Page 2 • Panel I: Captain Nakhuda rallying the crew to the port rail.



Page 2 • Panel J: The cracked pocket watch and the cycle renewed.

8. FUTURE SCOPE & ROADMAP

8.1 Additional Character Sprite Sheets & Animations

Currently, NPCs and the protagonist utilize high-contrast 2D pixel avatars. The future roadmap includes full 4-directional 12-frame walking sprite sheets for all 5 crew members and distinct role sashes for the protagonist (Blue for Navigator, Red for Quartermaster, Grey for Deckhand).

8.2 Manga Panels for Special Moments & Endings

The `MangaPage` engine is built to be reusable across all key dramatic moments:

- **Manga Moments (`MANGA_MOMENTS.md`):** 1–2 panel comic beats for discovering the safe code, examining the statue's clutching hand, and touching the humming Kaal Mani.
- **Manga Endings (`MANGA_ENDINGS.md`):** Fully staged 2-page cutscenes for *The Hero's Sacrifice* (`eh-a` through `eh-d` and `m-statue-a`), *Coward's End*, *Mutineer's Reign*, and *The Golden Path*.

8.3 Ghost Replay Recording Mechanics

Expanding the temporal puzzle system by recording the player's movement trajectory from the immediately preceding loop. The ghost will replay as a translucent figure, allowing solo players to solve two-person pressure plate puzzles (such as holding the Stern Helm plate while simultaneously firing cannons).

8.4 Extended Dynamic Audio & Voice Lines

Integrating dynamic audio stems that subtly detune and slow down as the 600s timeline expires, paired with full voice-acted opening narration in the salt-stained sailor idiom defined in `FEEL.md`.
